



Not local, but global:
Top officials of Tata and Corus shake hands after Tata's takeover in 2006

in one's own discipline. A photographer shooting wildlife will not be a professional unless he is able to understand why plant pathogens impact the eating habits of carnivores. If he is shooting in New York City, he needs to appreciate urban spaces, and a great shot on the outskirts of Delhi requires an understanding of where Delhi comes from historically.

Now I am beginning to understand why Dewitt Jones shoots for *National Geographic*. Lens knows he has me hooked.

"The third mind," Lens explains, "is the creative mind. Look, you are no photo professional. You are just a software guy building business solutions for your international clients. Ever thought about why, these days, your clients do not want the 'tried-and-tested' solutions to their problems anymore?"

I do not like Lens asking me such questions, because only he knows the answer. I just keep quiet whenever he pulls this Super Guru stunt. I know he will spill soon.

"Clients do not like the tried-and-the tested solutions any more because those solutions are simply not innovative enough. Precisely because they are tried and tested, they have become the past. Competitive advantage is about creativity, and creativity is about taking risks. The creative mind is about building the capacity to answer what is new and what is different about the solution you are suggesting every time."

I feign casual interest but I am listening

quite intently.

"The fourth mind is the respectful mind," Lens says.

Made in Japan, Lens becomes the Buddha at will.

"In the future, all problems will require interdisciplinary solutions. Whether it is about negotiating a nuclear treaty or removing a cancerous cell from the pancreas, if anything qualifies to be called a problem, then chances are high, the solution would have to be interdisciplinary. That means experts from different fields will have to listen to each other, learn from each other, collaborate while they compete, disagree without being disagreeable and then put multiple minds together, build consensus and emerge with the strength of the respectful mind. Why do you think one CEO fails and another succeeds in taking a militant trade union along? Why do you think one educationist prevails over others while settling the contents of a high school textbook on national history? Why one physicist is able to get agreement on making a certain standard universally acceptable in a transnational negotiation involving competing interests? Those who succeed have the respectful mind."

The rappelling wall is well behind us now. We are walking back. Actually, I am the one walking back and Lens is hanging around my neck. He thinks it is his rightful place.

"Finally, great professionals of tomorrow will need to understand and master what Howard Gardner calls the ethical mind. This ethical mind is about the capacity to certify the completion of one's own work. That rules out most people who need someone else to supervise them. Whatever may be your profession, to be called a professional, you must master all the five minds of the future and only then can you be globally accepted."

"But why should we worry about being globally relevant?" I hear myself mutter.

Lens retorts, "Because the benchmark no longer remains local. The benchmark is now Dewitt Jones."

Ahead of me, I see the road wind itself into a softly undulating sand dune. Behind the dune is the shimmering blue water of the Bay and beyond all that: Singapore, Tokyo, San Francisco, New York, London, Paris and Mumbai.

Future Perfect

A PHOTOGRAPHER SHOOTING WILDLIFE WILL NOT BE A PROFESSIONAL UNLESS HE IS ABLE TO UNDERSTAND WHY PLANT PATHOGENS IMPACT THE EATING HABITS OF CARNIVORES.

The author is the co-founder of MindTree. He also authored two books, The High Performance Entrepreneur and Go Kiss the World.